
CULTURE AND DIVERSITY IN
BANGLADESH

Culture and Society in Bangladesh

- Culture
- Linguistic Affiliation
- Symbolism
- National Identity
- Urbanism, Architecture, and the Use of Space
- Literature
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- The Culture of Bangladesh refers to the way of life of the people of Bangladesh. It has evolved over the centuries and encompasses the cultural diversity of several social groups in Bangladesh.

- Bangladeshi culture is manifested in various forms, including music, dance, and drama; arts and crafts; folklore and folktales; literature, fairs and festivals; as well as in a distinct cuisine and culinary tradition.
- The indigenous communities of Bangladesh have their own unique culture and traditions, rich in colorful diversity.



Linguistic Affiliation

- The primary language is Bangla, called Bengali by most non-natives, an Indo-European language spoken not just by Bangladeshis but also by culturally Bengali people. This includes about 300 million people from Bangladesh, West Bengal, and Bihar, as well as Bengali speakers in other Indian states—the language dates from well before the birth of Christ. Bangla varies by region, and people may not understand the language of a person from another district. However, differences in dialect consist primarily of slight differences in accent or pronunciation and minor grammatical usages.



- Language differences mirror social and religious divisions. Bangla is divided into two distinct forms: Sadhu Vasha, a learned or formal language, and Cholit Vasha, a common language. Sadhu basha is the language of the literate tradition, formal essays, and poetry, and the well-educated. Cholit Vasha is the spoken language (local language), the language of the great majority of Bengalis. Cholit Vasha is the medium by which the great majority of people communicate in a country in which 50 percent of men and 26 percent of women are literate. There are also small usage variations between Muslims and Hindus, along with minor vocabulary differences.





SYMBOLISM

- The most important symbol of national identity is the Bangla language.
- The flag is a dark green rectangle with a red circle just left of the center. Green symbolizes the trees and fields of the countryside; red represents the rising sun and the blood fallen in the 1971 war for liberation.
- The national anthem was taken from a poem by Nobel laureate Rabindranath Tagore and links a love of the natural realm and land with the national identity.



URBANISM, ARCHITECTURE, AND THE USE OF SPACE





Rural Architecture

- Houses in villages are commonly *rectangular, and are dried mud, bamboo, or red brick structures* with covering roofs.
- Houses *have little interior decoration, and wall space is reserved for storage.* Furniture is *minimal, often consisting only of low stools.*
- A *separate smaller mud or bamboo structure serves as a kitchen (ranna ghor),* but during the dry season many women construct hearths and cook in the household courtyard.



Urban Architecture

- Architectural styles in the cities show *numerous historical influences, including Moghul and Islamic motifs with curved arches,* windows, and minarets, and square *British colonial wood and concrete construction.*
- The National Parliament building (Shongshad Bhabon) in Dhaka, designed by the American architect Louis Kahn, reflects a synthesis of western modernity and curved Islamic-influenced spaces.
- The National Memorial in Savar, a wide-based spire that becomes narrower as it rises, is the symbol of the country's liberation. It is a monument dedicated to the memory of the martyrs of the Bangladesh Liberation War. Architect Syed Mainul Hossain designed it.



Literature

- The rich heritage of Bengali literature is almost a thousand years old.
- The first literary text in Bangla is the eighth century Charyapada.
- Like all other literatures, Bangla began with religious poetry, or more accurately, with devotional songs. From the days of the Charyapadas to the bulk of medieval literature, it was mostly theocentric, encompassing Buddhist, Hindu, and even Muslim literature.
- Some major Medieval poets of Bengal are Chandidas, Jayadeva, Vidyapati, Kasiram Das, Krittibas Ojha, Shah Muhammad Sagir, Daulat Kazi, Jainuddin, Sheikh Faizullah, Abdul Hakim and Daulat Uzir Bahram Khan

Literature

- Bangla literature in the medieval age was often either religious (e.g. Chandidas), or adaptations from other languages (e.g. Alaol).
  - **Chandi Das is known mainly for his lyrical “Srikrishnakirtan”**
  - **Daulat Kazi appointed as the court poet of King Sri Sudharma (of Arakan) for whom he composed the poem “Satimayna O Lorchandrani”**
  - **Alaol, a 17th-century Bengali poet, is renowned for his epic poem "Padmavati,"**
- Although during the medieval period, it remained largely Theocentric, Muslim poets like Shah Muhammed Sageer and Alaol introduced elements of romanticism, while Hindu poets expressed love allegorically through Vaishnava literature.
- The rise of syncretic sects like the Bauls and Sahajiyas added a distinct Bengali flavor, blending divine and human elements.



Literature

- A significant transformation occurred in the 19th century under the influence of English literature, leading to a humanistic Renaissance led by figures like Akshaykumar Datta, Vidyasagar, Michael Madhusudan Dutt, Bankim Chandra, and Rabindranath Tagore, who introduced Western forms such as sonnets, novels, and dramas.
- While the spread of education and print culture boosted urban literature, it also led to the decline of folk traditions, which were later revived by scholars and Tagore himself.
- Despite urbanization, the rural essence of Bengal remained central in the works of poets like Jibanananda Das and Jasimuddin. Over time, Muslim writers like Kaikobad, Meer Mosharraf Hussain, and Nazrul Islam helped bridge the literary gap between communities, as Bangla literature evolved into a rich tapestry of tradition, modernity, and cultural fusion.
- Michael Madhusudan Datta. Sarat Chandra Chattopadhaya, Bankim Chandra Chattopadhaya, Kaikobad, Mir Mosharraf Hossain and Kazi Ahdul Wadud are some of the pioneering writers of modern Bengali literature.



For more see: https://en.banglapedia.org/index.php?title=Bangla_Literature

FESTIVALS IN BANGLADESH

MAJOR FESTIVALS IN BANGLADESH

- Bangladesh is a land of festivals. There is a popular saying in Bangla ‘Baro Mashe Tero Paban’ meaning 13 festivals in 12 months. It is interesting to note that many of our festivals are linked to religions, seasons and specials occasions. In recent times, international festivals have also been added to the list. However, festivals can be grouped broadly into religious, nonreligious, indigenous and nonindigenous.
- **Festivals** are common to all societies and cultures. With the change of social and economic structures, the natures of festivals also change. But some festivals are so deeply rooted in the social organism that they continue to entertain from generation to generation. The festivals, which got started in the primitive society centering on the prayer for food, have now been filled with various colors and varieties.a



MAJOR FESTIVALS IN BANGLADESH

- For Muslim : Eid-e-Miladunnabi, Eid-ul-Fitr, Eid-ul-Azha, Muharram etc.
- Hindus observe Durga Puja, Saraswati Puja, Kali Puja and many other pujas.
- Christmas (popularly called Baradin in Bangla) is observed by Christians
- Some common festivities are observed all people irrespective of races.
- Pahela Baishakh (the first day of Bangla year) is such a festival.
- National festivals are Independence Day (26th March), 21st February (the National Marty's Day and Int'l Mother Language Day), The Victory Day (16th December), Rabindra & Nazrul Jayanti etc.



MAJOR FASTIVALS OF BANGLADESH

- POHELA BOISHAKH
- POHELA FALGUN
- LALON MELA
- THE KITE FLYING FESTIVAL
- INDEPENDENCE DAY
- INTERNATIONAL MOTHER LANGUAGE DAY
- NABANNA
- EKUSHEY BOI MELA
- Dhaka International Trade Fair
- Eid Ul Fitr
- Eid Ul Adha
- MUHARRAM
- CHIRSTMAS
- DURGA PUJA



POHELA BOISHAKH

- The first day of Bangla year is celebrated as Pahela Boishakh. The day is celebrated with festivity across the country. It is celebrated in villages and towns. People in the village celebrate this day according to their age-old customs. Special meals are arranged at home.
- Baisakhi melas are held in different places. In towns, various socio-cultural organizations arrange interesting programs on this day. At Ramna Batamul, it is celebrated gorgeously. Many urban people wake up early in the morning and go to the function to enjoy poem reciting, songs, stage drama, lecture, etc.
- Many people eat panta hilisa in the morning. Children put on colorful dresses. They go to the Boishakhi Mela and buy sweets, toys, dolls, and handmade things. They enjoy the day with great pleasure.



POHELA FALGUN

Bangladesh is a country were colorful fairs and festivals. In our Bangladesh, the spring season stays for two months [Falgun and Chaitra]. A colorful festival held to welcome Bashanto. Attired in reddish-yellow saris with red border and hairs decorated with flowers, young women and girls as well as young men and boys in traditional pajama and punjabi, carrying flowers, took part in the colorful march. A good number of kids also got their attractive faces painted with different motifs including birds, national flag, butterflies etc. Pahela Falgun is celebrated on February 13. It is called the 'Rituraj Bashonto'.





LALON MELA

Lalon song is called the song of a spiritual anthem. Every year, a five-day long fair is organized at Kushtia on the eve of Baul Fakir Lalon Shah's death anniversary otherwise known as 'Tirodhn Dibosh.' Lalon Mela or Fair is held in here twice every year. Once during Dol Purnima festival and again on 1st of Kartik. The akhra (a place where Lalon lived) is colorfully decorated where thousands of Lalon devotees gather from different locations of the country to celebrate his philosophical thoughts by performing his thousands of composition.

Mausoleum of Lalon Shah or Lalon Akhara is the burial place of Baul Emperor Lalon, and a shrine built around this grave. The shrine is located in the village of Cheuriya in Kumarkhali Upazila of Kushtia District.



THE KITE FLYING FESTIVAL

- In Bangladesh, each season has its individual way of representing nature here.
- Shakrain Festival (also known as Kite Festival and Ghuri Utsob) is an annual Bengali celebration in Dhaka, Bangladesh, observed with the flying of kites.
- The celebration is uniquely celebrated by the Bengali Muslim Dhakaiya community based on Old Dhaka. It occurs at the end of Poush, the ninth month of the Bengali calendar (January 14 or 15 on a leap year, according to the Gregorian calendar). This day is known as Poush Sankranti.
- Shakrain Festival is one of the oldest annual festivals of Bangladesh. It is a famous and a significant event in Bangladeshi culture. It is the symbol of unity and friendship in Bangladesh.
- The clear blue sky gets packed with high-flying kites in different colors and shapes

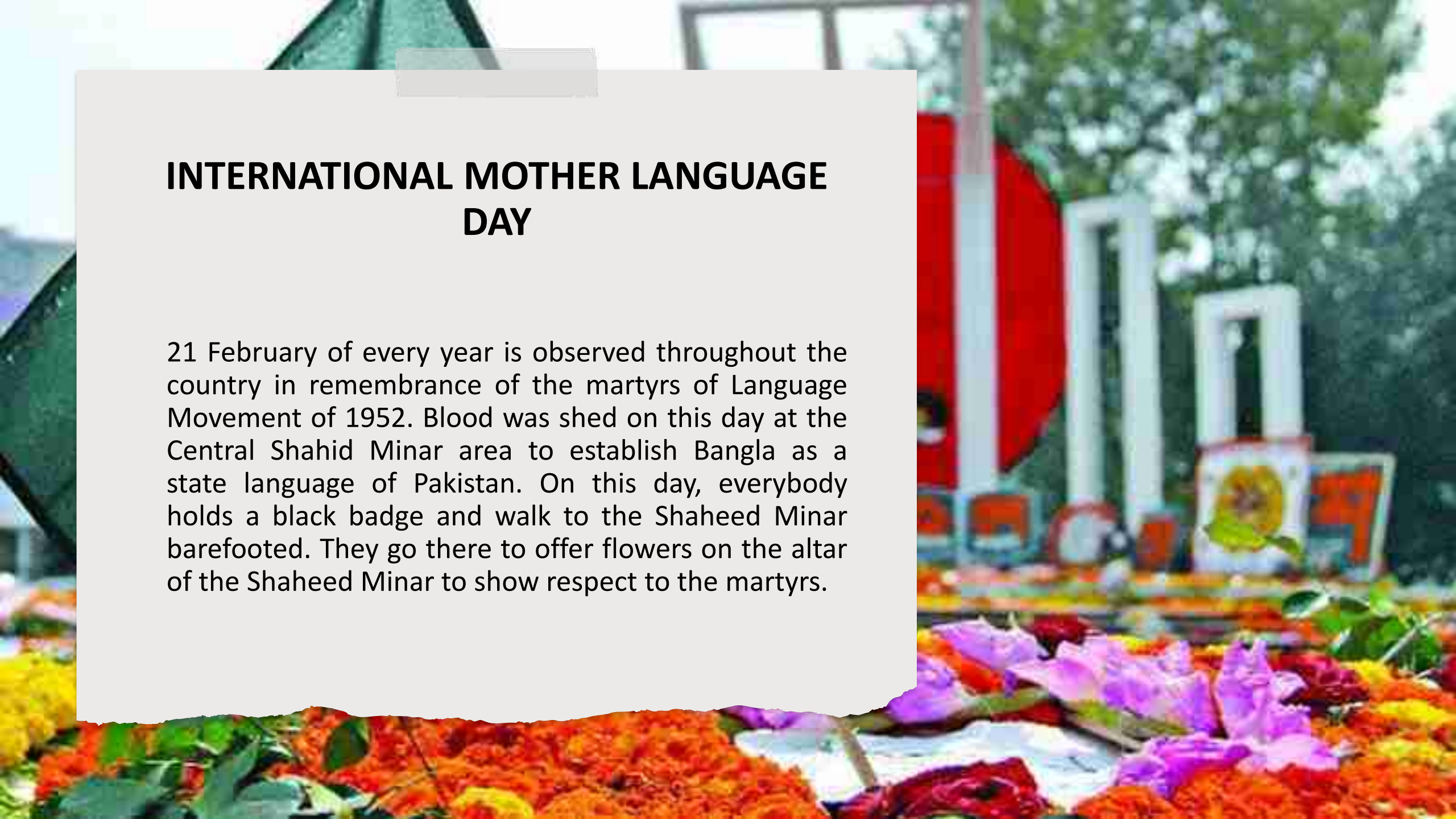


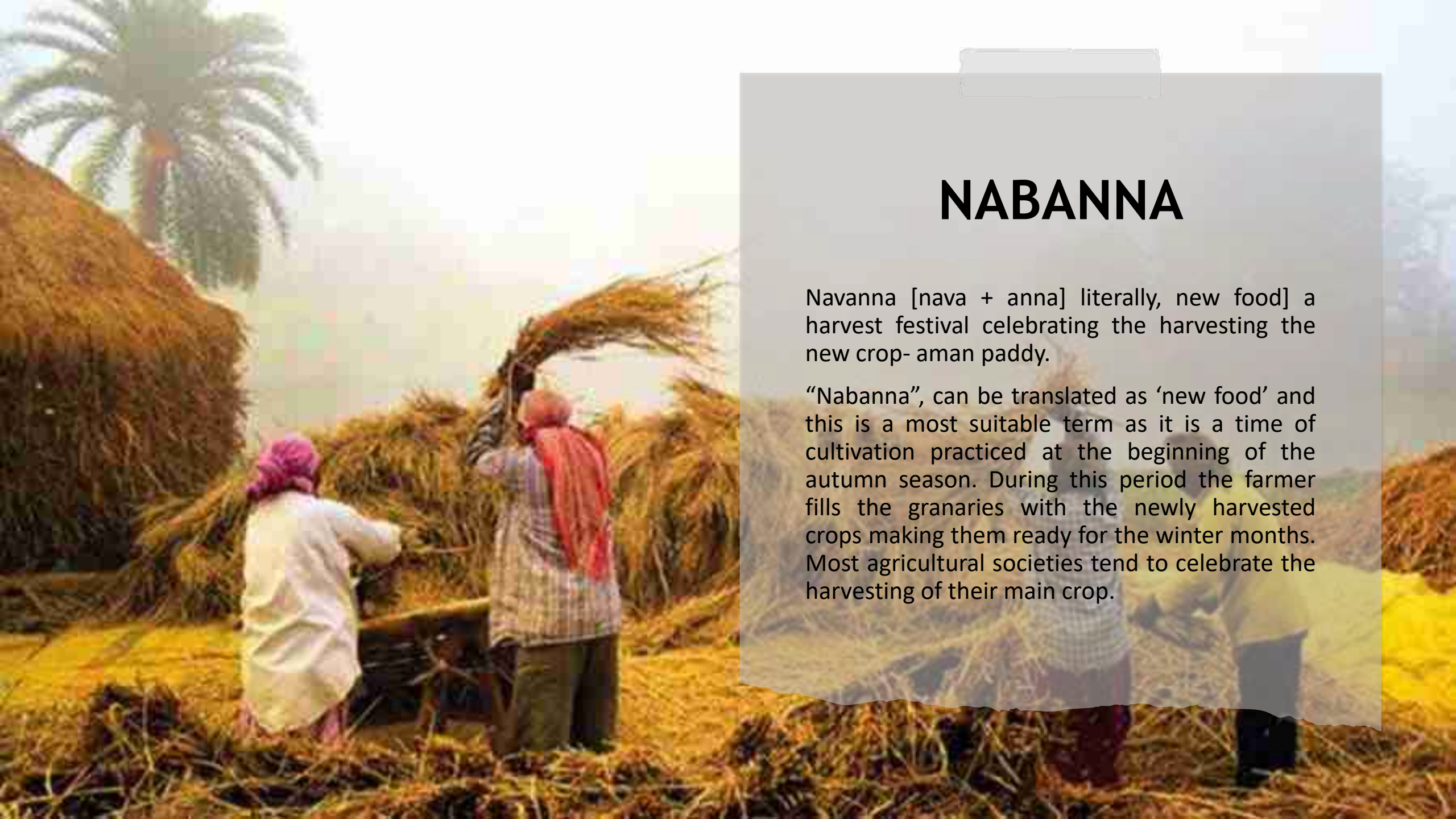
INDEPENDENCE DAY

The biggest state festival, the Independence day (March 26) is observed throughout the country. All major cities wear a festive look. It is a public holiday. The citizens of Dhaka wake up early in the morning to the sound of booming guns heralding the day. Leaders of the government, political and social organizations, freedom fighters and ordinary citizens alike place floral wreaths at the National Martyrs' Memorial at Savar.

INTERNATIONAL MOTHER LANGUAGE DAY

21 February of every year is observed throughout the country in remembrance of the martyrs of Language Movement of 1952. Blood was shed on this day at the Central Shahid Minar area to establish Bangla as a state language of Pakistan. On this day, everybody holds a black badge and walk to the Shaheed Minar barefooted. They go there to offer flowers on the altar of the Shaheed Minar to show respect to the martyrs.

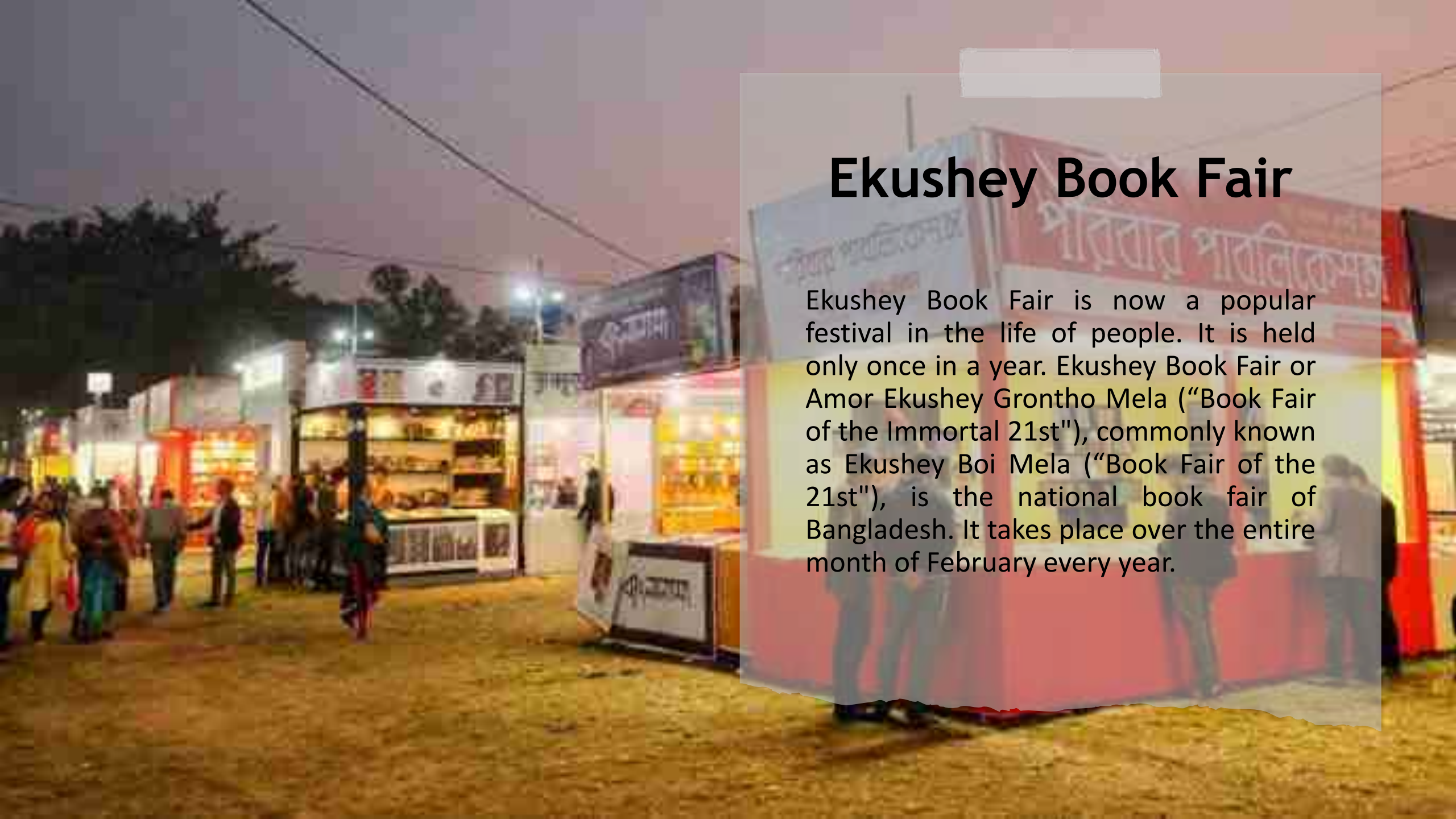




NABANNA

Navanna [nava + anna] literally, new food] a harvest festival celebrating the harvesting the new crop- aman paddy.

“Nabanna”, can be translated as ‘new food’ and this is a most suitable term as it is a time of cultivation practiced at the beginning of the autumn season. During this period the farmer fills the granaries with the newly harvested crops making them ready for the winter months. Most agricultural societies tend to celebrate the harvesting of their main crop.



Ekushey Book Fair

Ekushey Book Fair is now a popular festival in the life of people. It is held only once in a year. Ekushey Book Fair or Amor Ekushey Grontho Mela (“Book Fair of the Immortal 21st"), commonly known as Ekushey Boi Mela (“Book Fair of the 21st"), is the national book fair of Bangladesh. It takes place over the entire month of February every year.



Dhaka International Trade Fair

Dhaka International Trade Fair is an international trade fair in Bangladesh. It is organized by the Export Promotion Bureau together with the Ministry of Commerce of the Government of Bangladesh. DITF is held from the first week of January to the first week of February every year.



Eid Ul Fitr

Eid and fitr are arabic words. Eid means festival and fitr means to open, to break fasting, to go back to normal situation. The joyous three-day celebration, Eid ul-Fitr falls on the first day of Shawwal(the tenth month in the Islamic (Hijri) calendar), the month which follows Ramadan in the Islamic calendar. However, the celebrations begin upon the sighting of the new moon which marks the end of the month of fasting and prayer.

The day is usually characterized by praying Eid prayers, spending time with loved ones, and enjoying good food.

Eid-ul Fitr is celebrated in Bangladesh with great joy. On this day, everyone tries to dress well and prepare improved foods according to their ability. Relatives and neighbors also share the joys of this festival.



Eid Ul Adha

Eid ul-Adha also known as the Feast of sacrifice falls on the 10th day of the Islamic calendar's last month, Dhu al-Hijjah. All over the world, Muslims who can afford a cow, goat, or sheep sacrifice it as a reminder of Ibrahim's obedience to Allah.

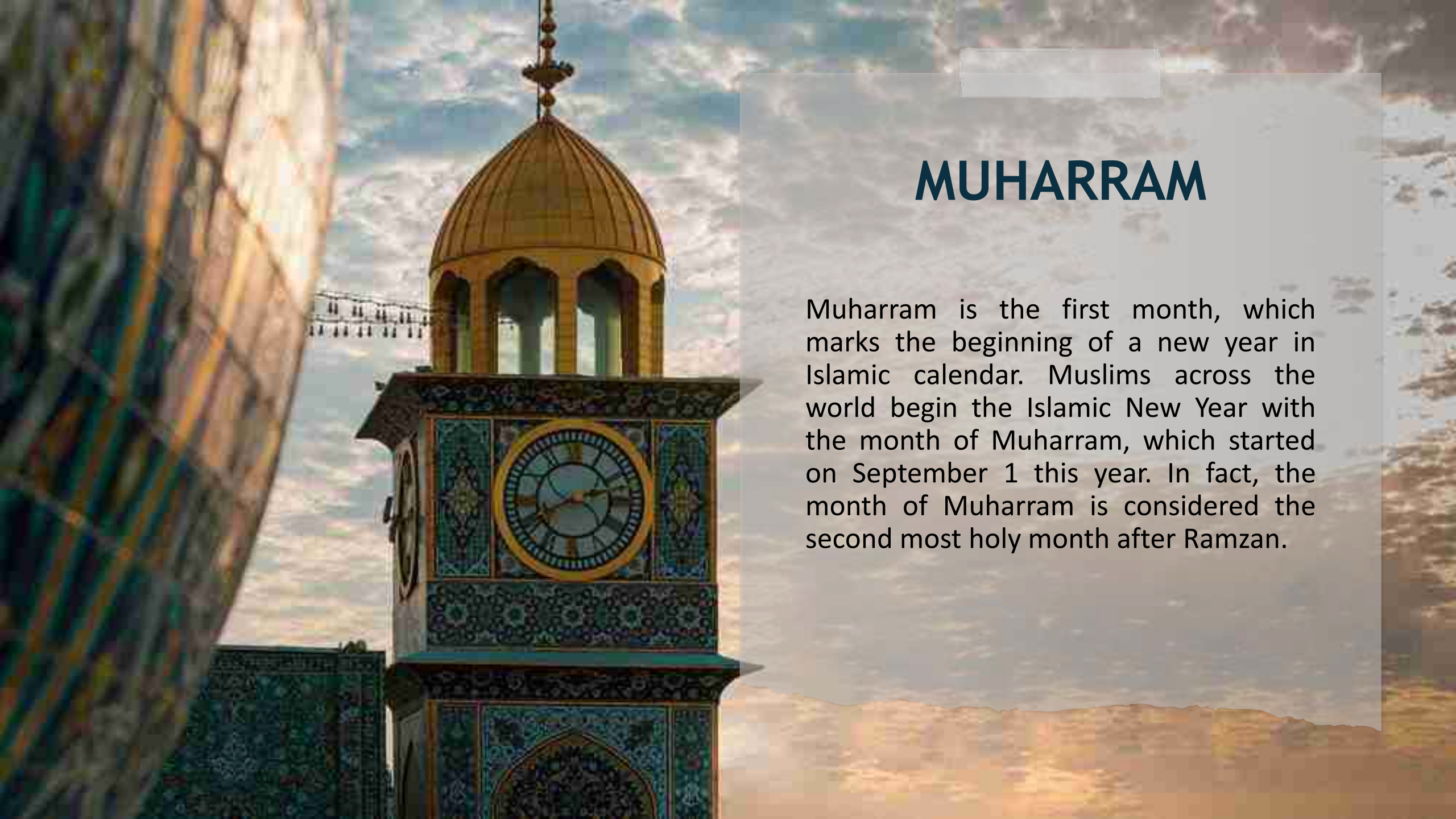
Animal sacrifice in the name of Allah is a major feature of Eid-ul Azha. From the sacrifice and through the distribution of sacrificial meat to the poor and distressed, one gets spiritual satisfaction and pleasure, which obtains a socially festive character.

Like all other Muslims of the world, Muslims of Bangladesh celebrate Eid-ul Azha in an appropriate manner of religious fervor and enthusiasm. New clothes and accessories are bought on the occasion. People, dressed in new clothes, visit the houses of neighbors and relatives to exchange greetings and partake of the special foods prepared on the occasion.



CHIRSTMAS

Christmas, known as "Bara Din" or The Big Day in Bangla is celebrated with festivities in Dhaka and elsewhere in the country. Functions include illumination of churches, decorating Christmas tree & other festivities.



MUHARRAM

Muharram is the first month, which marks the beginning of a new year in Islamic calendar. Muslims across the world begin the Islamic New Year with the month of Muharram, which started on September 1 this year. In fact, the month of Muharram is considered the second most holy month after Ramzan.

DURGA PUJA

- Durga Puja, the biggest festival of the Hindu community in the country, continues for ten days with the last three days being the most joyful. The festivities culminate with the idol of goddess Durga immersed in the river.
- A series of festivals centering Durga Puja is held in Bangladesh. Usually on the sixth lunar day of the bright fortnight in the Bengali month of Axwin, the ceremonial awakening of goddess Durga takes place. Thereafter, Puja is performed for three days on the seventh, eighth and ninth, and the immersion of the image of the goddess Durga with her companions is held on the tenth day. The series of Pujas(Lakshmi, Kali, Kartik)which starts in Axwin with Durga, comes to an end with Saraswati.





Buddha Purnima

- Buddha Purnima is the main religious festival of the Buddhist community. The day is known as 'Buddha Purnima' because three important events in the life of the great Buddha took place on this full moon day of the month of Vaishakh. Gautama Buddha was born on this day in 623 BC, on this day in 588 BC he attained enlightenment and became known as the Buddha in the world, and on this day in 543 BC he attained Mahaparinirvana. Buddhism was introduced to the world through Siddhartha's enlightenment.
- On the day of Buddha Purnima, Buddhists organize Buddha Puja, Panchashil, Ashtashil, Sutra reading, Sutra listening, congregational prayers, and various auspicious events. They contemplate Buddha remembrance and Sangha remembrance. Along with various worship and rituals, various social, cultural, and religious events are also organized.



BANGLADESHI CUISINE



- Bangladesh is a land of vibrant culture and rich culinary traditions. Its cuisine is heavily influenced by its geography, history, and neighboring countries. Bangladesh is renowned for its rich variety of delicious foods, known for their rich and flavorful taste.
- The culinary tradition of the country places a strong emphasis on the use of aromatic spices and fresh ingredients.
- Rice is the staple food in Bangladesh and is typically served with an array of flavorful side dishes. Among the most common and traditional meals enjoyed by the general population is the classic combination of rice, fish, vegetables and lentils (commonly known as "machhe-bhate-bangalee").
- In addition to its savory cuisine, Bangladesh is also celebrated for its mouthwatering desserts. The country boasts a wide assortment of sweets, rice-based puddings, and milk-based delicacies. Most of these desserts are prepared using rice, cow’s milk, and natural sweeteners like jaggery or sugar, resulting in rich and comforting treats that are enjoyed on both special occasions and in everyday life.

POPULAR BANGLADESHI DISHES

Kacchi Biryani

This fragrant rice dish is made with layers of meat, potatoes, and spices.



Bhuna Khichuri

This hearty lentil and rice stew is a popular comfort food..



Morog Polao

This flavorful rice dish is made with chicken, onions, and spices.



Panta Ilish

A popular breakfast dish made with hilsa fish soaked in mustard oil and spices.



SWEET TREATS OF BANGLADESH

Roshogolla
A syrupy dessert made with cottage cheese and soaked in sugar syrup.



Mishti Doi
A sweet yogurt made with milk, sugar, and a hint of cardamom.



Jilapi
A sweet and sticky dessert made with deep-fried dough soaked in sugar syrup.



Rasmalai
This sweet cheese dessert is made with milk, sugar, and saffron.



TRADITIONAL FOODS

- “মাছে ভাতে বাঙালি”
- “Panta Elish” in Pohela Boishak.
- “Pitha Puli” in Nobanno Uthshob.
- “Vapa pitha, Chitoy Pitha” in Winter.
- Friday Special Lunch.







MUSIC IN BANGLADESH



Music

- Bangla music, like its literature, boasts a rich heritage.
- The oldest form of music is the Charyapadas, and much of Bengal's medieval poetry was originally composed as songs, often specifying the raga (melody) and tala (rhythm) for performance.
- A significant blend of classical and folk music appeared in the form of ***KIRTANS***—devotional songs shaped by medieval Vaishnava singers.
- Folk music, nurtured through the ages by village bards, is the most popular and timeless form of music in Bangladesh. Rich in devotional mysticism and romanticism, folk music exudes the authentic flavor and charm of the soil.
- The most well-known forms are Bhatiali, Baul, Marfati, Murshidi, Bhaoaiya and Gombhira.



Some major genres of early Bengali Music

- Charjapaad
- Panchali
- Nathgeeti
- Dharma Mongol
- Geetagobindo
- Shakto Geeti
- Sree Krishna Kirtaan
- Tappa Gaan
- Boishnab Padaboli
- Mongol Kabbo
- Monosha Mongol
- Chandi Mongol

Music

- Generally, Bangladeshi music can be categorized into a number of categories. The main categories are: Classical music, Rabindra sangeet, Nazrul Geeti, Folk songs, Adhunik gaan and Modern music with western influences.
- Each of these categories is very broad and can incorporate a number of different styles and musical movements.
- The most distinguishable characteristic of classical music is that it is based on raqas modes.
- Rabindra sangeet is more often characterized by the words used, which are usually either prayer songs, love songs, seasonal songs or patriotic songs. All Rabindra sangeet music has a theme of philosophy and love and often they incorporate masterful poetry.
- Nazrul geeti is more easily classified because all musical works in this category incorporate the works of Kazi Nazrul Islam, one of the country's national poets and a major revolutionist. The style tends to incorporate revolutionary thoughts as well as spiritual and philosophical themes.



Folk Music

- All folk songs are characterized by simple musical structure and words. Before the arrival of radio, stage performances of folk singers used to be possibly the only entertainment for the vast rural population of Bengal. After the arrival of new communication and digital media, many of folk songs were modernized and incorporated into modern songs (Adhunik sangeet).
- Most folk songs relate to the particular lifestyles of various types of people such as solitaries, fishermen, and cart drivers. They have survived from generation to generation and often include words of worship to various Bengali gods.
- **Baul:** Baul is the most commonly known category of Bangladeshi folk songs. performed by solitaries, followers of Sufism. The Baul tradition, rooted in magic spirituality, produced another distinct type, characterized by simplicity and depth, with Lalon Shah (1774–1890) as its most prominent figure. Simple words express songs with deeper meanings involving the creation, society, lifestyle, and human emotions. little musical support is needed, the main carrier is the vocal.
- **Lalon songs:** Best known of all folk songs and the most import subgenre of Baul songs, almost entirely attributed to spiritual writer and composer, Lalon Fokir of Kushtia. He is also known as “Baul Samrat”





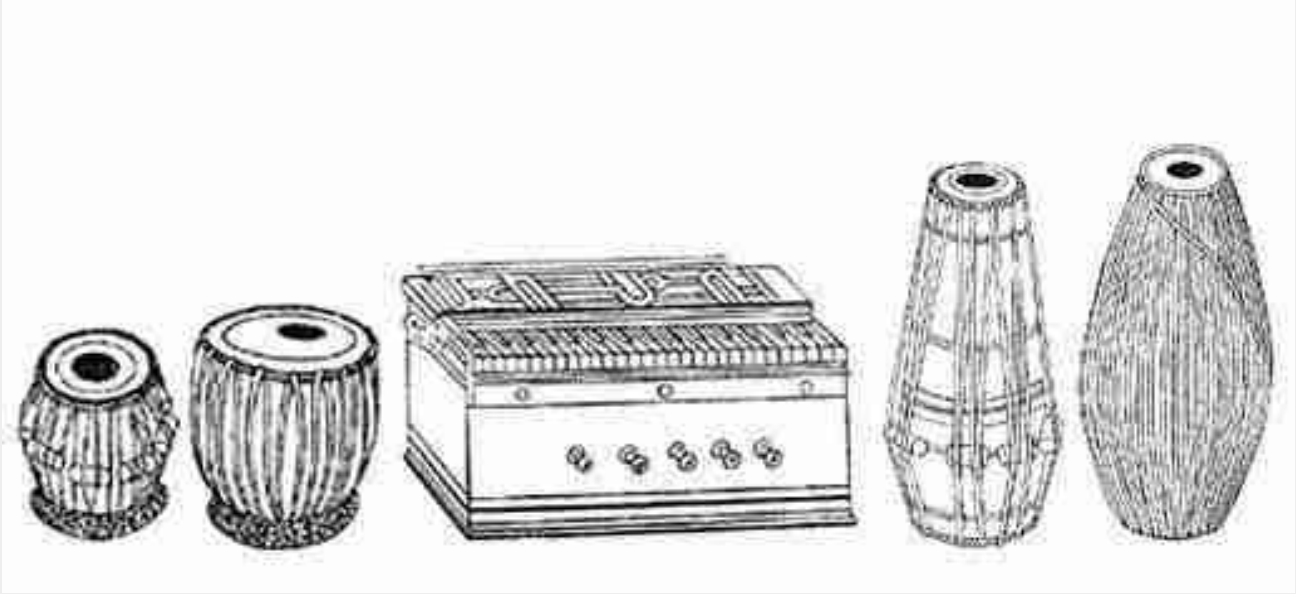
Folk Music

- **Bhatiyali :** These types of songs are generally sung by boatmen. It is seen in nearly all regions of Bangladesh, basically the riverside area.
- **Bhawaiya:** Bhawaiya a category of north Bengal folk song, believed to have originated in Rangpur and Cooch Bihar, India. The name of this folk song, generally about love between man and woman, derives from bhava (emotion). Bhawaiya songs, however, may also be spiritual in theme as in 'fande pariya baga kande re' (The heron cries entrapped in a net), 'chhar re man bhaver khela' (O my mind, leave earthly games), etc.
- **Jarigan:** Jarigan is sung like Charya by groups. This type of song are sung in Dhaka, Mymensingh, Sylhet, and Faridpur.
- **Hason Raja:** Devotional songs written by a music composer Hason Raja of Sylhet, northeastern side of Bangladesh near Assam. Recently it is repopularised as dance music.

Traditional Instruments

Bangladesh has a good number of musical instruments originally of her own. Those instruments are mainly used for folk music

- Ektara/ Dotara
- Dhol/Dholakk
- Khamak
- Bansuri and shanai
- Kartal
- Dugdugi



Paintings

- Rich tradition of modern painting pioneered by Zainul Abedin, Kamrul Hassan, Anwarul Haque, Shafiuddin Ahmed and S. M. Sultan.
- Zainul Abedin earned international fame for his sketches on famine of 1943 in Bangladesh.
- Other famous artists of Bangladesh are Abdur Razzak, Qayyum Chowdhury, Murtaza Baseer, Aminul Islam, Debdas Chakraborty, Kazi Abdul Baset, Syed Jahangir, and Mohammad Kibria



Drama and Dance

- **Drama:** Drama in Bangladesh has an old tradition and is very popular .Popular theatre groups are Dhaka Theatre, Nagarik Nattya Sampraday and Theatre. In Dhaka, Baily Road area is known as 'Natak Para' where drama shows are regularly held.
- **Dance:** Classical forms of the sub-continent predominate in Bangladeshi dance. The folk, tribal and Middle Eastern traits are also common. Among the tribal dances, particularly popular are Monipuri and Santal.





Jatra

- Jatra (Folk Drama) is another vital chapter of Bangalee culture. It represents mythological episodes of love and tragedy. Legendary plays of heroism are also popular, particularly in the rural areas. In near past jatra was the biggest entertainment means for the rural Bangalees and in that sense for 80% of the population since the same percentage of the population lived in rural Bangladesh.

Traditional Transportation Means

In rural areas bullock carts, buffalo carts and tomtoms (horse carts) are commonly used. In old Dhaka once tomtom was a common vehicle and still it is found, though rare. Bicycles are used both in rural and urban areas. Palki (a box-like vehicle carried on shoulders by six men) is a wedding transportation means. Brides are carried to the bridegrooms' places by Palki.













Folk Art and Crafts in Bangladesh

Art and Crafts

Folk art and crafts are *traditional cultural expressions* that have evolved over centuries through **age-old practices**. The boundary between *art* and *craft* is often blurred. For example, **floor and wall paintings** or **nakshi kantha** are considered folk art, while the creations of **potters, carpenters, weavers**, and items made from **bamboo, cane, shola, conch-shell, ivory, and bell-metal** are generally classified as crafts.

Some objects, however, blend both elements. A **painted earthen pot** or **decorative cane mat** with images of trees, birds, or mosques represent a fusion of **artistic design and practical craft**.

Folk art typically fulfills *religious, social,* and *aesthetic* needs and is created by **community-based artisans**.

Most materials used are humble and natural, such as **clay, wood, cloth, thread, sola, conch-shell, reeds, bamboo, cane**, and **animal horn**. Though **gold jewelry** is not considered folk art, ornaments made from **copper, brass**, and **silver** often are.
The tools used in folk craftsmanship are **simple and traditional**. For example, a **village goldsmith** may use **primitive tools** and sit **crouched over a small flame**, crafting with deep skill and inherited knowledge.



Folk Arts and Gender Role

Much of women's folk art has been non-commercial, whereas **the folk art produced by men has a commercial value** attached to it. Thus, **blacksmiths, potters, cobblers, painters, goldsmiths, brass-smiths, weavers** earn their livelihood from what they produce. Traditionally, in the past, **alpana artists** or **nakshi kantha needlewomen** were working within the home and received **no monetary recompense** for their labour.





Traditional Motifs and Symbolism in Folk Art

- **Folk art uses traditional motifs reflecting the land and its people.** Different forms of folk art tend to repeat these common motifs. For instance, **the lotus, the sun, the tree-of-life, flowery creepers** etc are seen in **paintings, embroidery, weaving, carving, and engraving**.
- Other common motifs include:
    - **Fish**
    - **Elephant**
    - **Horse**
    - **Peacock**
    - **Swastika**
    - **Circle**
    - **Waves**
    - **Temple**
    - **Mosque** etc.
- Many of these motifs have **symbolical meanings**. For example:
    - **Fish** represents *fertility*
    - **Sheaf of paddy** represents *prosperity*
    - **Lotus** represents *purity,* and
    - **Swastika** — usually more curvilinear than the Nazi symbol — represents *good fortune*.

Categories of Folk Art

Folk art may be divided into the following categories:

1.Painting:

1. Floor painting,
2. Stage scenery,
3. Painted pots,
4. Masks,
5. Wall painting,
6. Tattooing and other body painting,
7. Chal chitra,
8. Karandichitra (*Manasa tales on a sola canvas*),
9. Fancy pots, fancy dolls, etc.

2.Embroidery:

1. Nakshi kantha,
2. Nakshi pakha,
3. Handkerchiefs, etc.

3.Weaving:

1. Fancy mats,
2. Nakshi shika,
3. Fancy fans,
4. Baskets,
5. Flower vases.

4. Modelling:

1. Dolls and toys,
2. Utensils,
3. Masks,
4. Moulds for making cakes and sweets,
5. Ornaments.

5. Engraving:

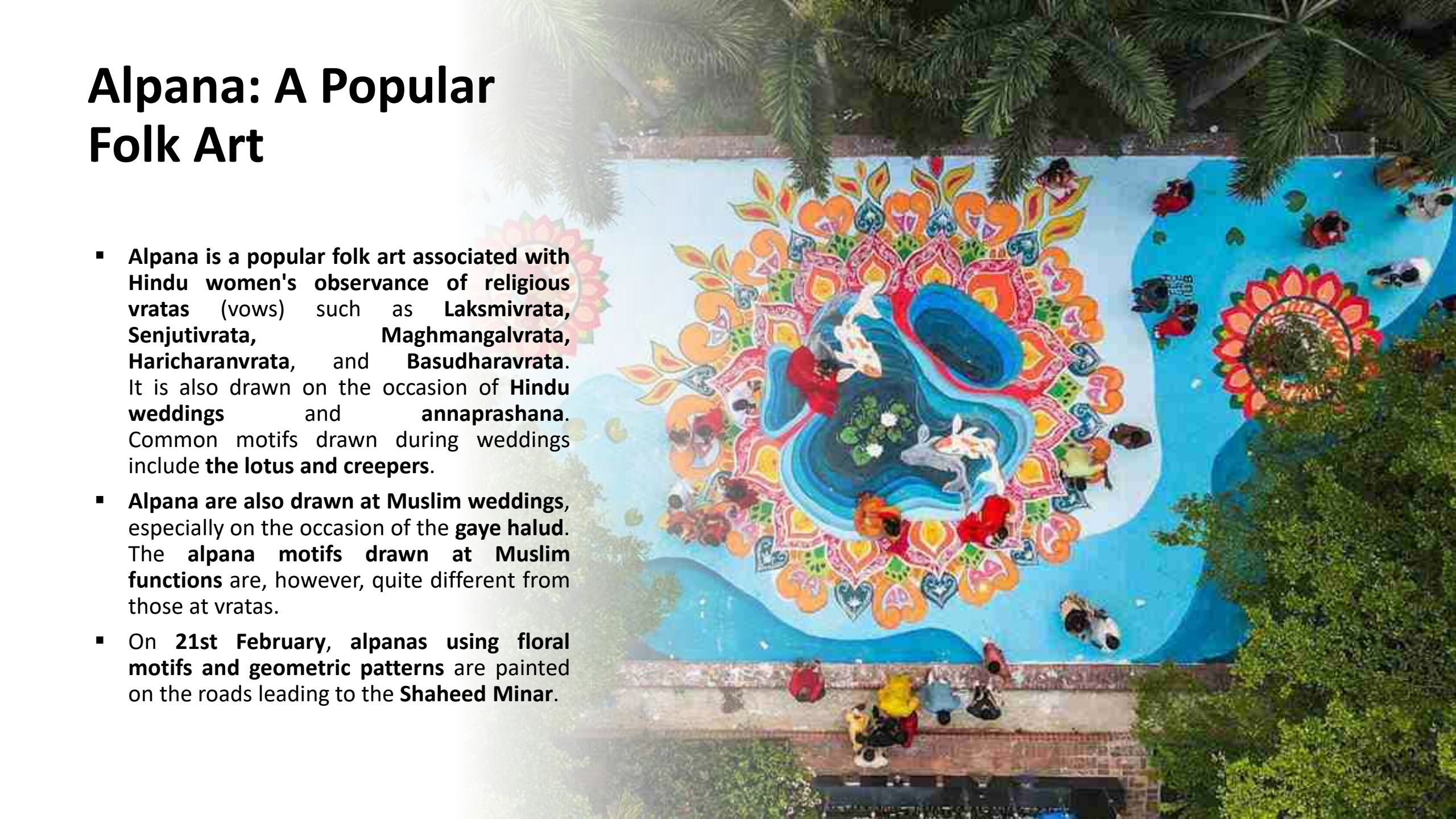
1. Wooden products,
2. Terracotta slabs,
3. Metal works.

6. Inlaying:

1. Ornaments inlaid with gems, pearls, diamond, and other precious stones,
2. Decorating buildings and houses with coloured glass and stones.

Alpana: A Popular Folk Art

- **Alpana is a popular folk art associated with Hindu women's observance of religious vratas** (vows) such as **Laksmivrata, Senjutivrata, Maghmangalvrata, Haricharanvrata**, and **Basudharavrata**. It is also drawn on the occasion of **Hindu weddings** and **annaprashana**. Common motifs drawn during weddings include **the lotus and creepers**.
- **Alpana are also drawn at Muslim weddings**, especially on the occasion of the **gaye halud**. The **alpana motifs drawn at Muslim functions** are, however, quite different from those at vratas.
- On **21st February**, **alpanas using floral motifs and geometric patterns** are painted on the roads leading to the **Shaheed Minar**.



Materials and Techniques of Alpana

- **White paste made of pounded rice** is the **main raw material** for making **alpana**. Depending on the occasion, other materials such as **brick powder**, **ash**, **water mixed with cow dung**, **vermilion**, and **turmeric paste** are also used.
- For **vratas**, alpanas are drawn with **a finger** or **a piece of wood**. In **urban areas**, however, **enamel paints** and **brushes** are commonly used for painting alpanas.
- Alpana motifs do not show **realistic details**.
- The **Senjutivrata alpana**, representing a **woman with many children**, is depicted with **abstract lines**.
- The **Laksmivrata alpana**, symbolizing **Goddess Laksmi's foot**, is shown simply as **a human footprint**.



Bamboo Craft

Bamboo is used to make **houses** as well as **essential implements for farming, fishing**, and **domestic use**. It is also utilized in creating **musical instruments** such as the **Ektara** and the **flute**. **Bamboo fences and partitions** are often **decorated with floral motifs and geometric patterns**. **Fancy fans** made of bamboo depict **trees, birds, elephants, flowers**, and **conch-shaped leaves**.



Cane Craft

Like bamboo, **cane** is also used to produce a variety of **household** and **fancy products**, including **furniture**. **Chairs, stools, sofa sets, bookshelves, baskets, table lamps, partitions**, and **hookah holders** are attractive and affordable.

Though **less commonly used** in **urban areas**, **fancy mats** called **Nakshi Pati** (*pictorial mat*) or **Shitalpati** (*cool mat*) continue to be in demand for their **comfort** and **attractiveness**.





Jute Craft

Apart from being the raw material for **hessian and carpets**, **jute** is also used to make **mats, bags**, and **hanging string bags** or **sika**, used in homes to **hang foodstuff out of the reach of animals**.
To make **sikas**, **jute twine** is **braided** and then tied in various patterns such as **Taraful**, **Puntiful**, and **Takaful**.
The **sikas** are given different names such as **Muthashika**, **Chakshika**, **Kadishika**, and **Nengtashika** based on their **size, shape, and designs**. **Kadishika**, for example, is threaded with **cowries**.



Conchshell Craft

Conch shells are used to make **bangles, armlets, rings, lockets, buttons, hairpins**, and **clips**. Other items like **vermilion containers, incense holders, ashtrays, table lamps**, etc., are also crafted from shells. Despite their **primitive technology**, the **conch-cutters of Shankhari Patti in Dhaka** produce **finely crafted articles**.



Nakshi Kantha

Nakshi kantha or **embroidered quilt** is made and used almost everywhere in Bangladesh.
However, the **nakshi kanthas of Rajshahi, Jessore, and Faridpur** are most famous for their **stitchcraft and picturesque designs**.
Several **layers of old cloth** are put together to make these quilts.
Apart from being used to make **bedspreads and quilts**, **nakshi kantha work** is also used for making:

- **Pillow cases and covers**
- **Prayer mats**
- **Seats for puja**
- **Small bags** for keeping mirrors and combs
- **Gilaf** (covers) for books
- **Covers for foods**
- **Dastarkhan** or **dining mats**

Metalcraft

Gold and silver ornaments, and **plates, glasses, pitchers, and mugs** made of **silver and bell metal** have been in use since ancient times. Other items include:

- **Flower vases**
- **Ashtrays**
- **Table lamps**
- **Containers for cosmetics**
- **Various decoration pieces**

Various **motifs** such as **flowers, creepers, birds**, and **geometric patterns** are engraved on pitchers, glasses, and mugs. **Gold and silver ornaments**, to adorn women from **head to foot**, are made in **innumerable designs**.

Traditional ornaments include:

- **Makaramukhi mal** (the makara-faced anklet), an anklet designed in the shape of the **makara**
- **Lockets** designed like **flowers, butterflies**, and **geometric patterns** Ornaments are also **set with precious cut stones, gems, and pearls**.





Folk Art and Crafts

- **Nakshi Pitha** or decorative cakes are made by shaping dough of pounded rice into various designs. These are then **fried in oil** and soaked in **sugar syrup**. **Traditional motifs** for **NAKSHI PITHA** are geometric patterns, **wheels**, **betel leaf**, **flowers in bloom**, **fish**, **birds**, etc. **Nakshi pithas** are more popular in **Dhaka** and **Mymensingh** and are especially made to entertain guests at **weddings**.
- **Ornamental Woodwork**: A variety of **motifs** and **designs** are carved on **doors**, **windows**, **pillars**, **joists**, **rafters**, **chests**, **beds**, **divans**, **low seats**, **cake moulds**, **cases of musical instruments**, **palanquins**, **chariots**, **boats**, and **dolls**. Common motifs include the **lotus**, **birds**, **flowery creepers**, **circles**, and **geometric designs**.
- **Sola Craft**: **Sola** or **spongewood**, obtained from a plant that grows in **paddy fields** and **shallow water-bodies**, is used to make a variety of **decorative articles**. Traditional articles include **backdrops** for images of **deities** and **topar**, or **headgear**, for brides and bridegrooms. **Topars** are usually decorated with **kadam flowers**. Other items include **dolls**, **birds**, **elephants**, **flowers**, **boats**, **garlands**, etc.



Folk Art and Crafts

Daruchitra: The art of **wood engraving** is an ancient craft, used for decorating **door frames**, **pillars**, **windows**, **palanquins**, **boat prows**, **toys**, and **dolls**. The **designs** are carved out, and the plain surfaces are then **painted**.

Dewalchitra or **wall painting**: **Images of deities** are painted on the walls of **mud houses** in **northern Bengal** in the belief that these images will protect the house and its inmates from **evil**. **Flowers** and **leaves** are painted to beautify the dwelling place. Apart from **alpana designs**, motifs include the **swastika**, the **goddess Lakshmi** seated on a **lotus**, the **heroes of the PURANA**, **sheaves of paddy**, **creepers**, **peacocks**, and **elephants**.

Gazir Pat: A form of **scroll painting**, used to illustrate the life of **Gazi Pir**, king of tigers. Painted in **panel form**, these illustrations depict various **miraculous events** associated with **Gazi Pir**. One such panel shows Gazi seated on a **tiger** with its tail lifted. There are still one or two **patuyas** in **Munshiganj** and **Narsingdi** who paint **Gazir Pat**.

Folk Art and Crafts

Painted Masks: In many **folk festivals**, artists would wear **painted masks**. In **religious dances**, the performers would wear masks depicting the faces of the **deities**. **Shiva's face**, for example, would be made by dabbing **mud** on a piece of cloth fixed around a wooden frame. **Kali's face** was painted **blue**, her **eyes** white and black, and her **tongue** red.

Patachitra or **scroll paintings** by professional artists, known as **PATUYAS**, are used to illustrate different **narratives**. These scroll paintings date back to the **Buddhist period**, when **Buddhist bhikkus** known as 'maskari' used to spread the message of **BUDDHISM** by showing pictures to illustrate stories of the **Buddha**. Subsequently, during **Hindu rule**, these scroll paintings depicted stories from the **Puranas**.

Pottery: Inexpensive **household utensils** are made of **clay**, as are **images of Hindu gods** and goddesses for **pujas** and **devotional rites**. **Dolls**, **toys**, and **decoration pieces** are also made in most parts of Bangladesh. Some **clay products** are decorated with designs of **leaves**, **flowers**, **birds**, etc., while others are left **plain**.

Sakher Handi or **clay pots** painted with motifs of **fish**, **birds**, **lotus**, **leaves**, and **geometric designs** in bold brush strokes. Common **colours** are **red**, **yellow**, and **green**. Both motifs and colours are symbolic of **fertility**, which is why these pots are used to carry **gifts of fruit** and **sweets** at weddings. **Rajshahi** is well known for these pots.





Family and Kinship

- **Family and Kinship** are central to **social life** in Bangladesh. The **bari** (homestead) serves as the core unit for **economic**, **social**, and **landholding activities**. **Rural households** are often **extended families** sharing a kitchen, with **married sons** living under their **fathers' authority** and **wives** under their **mothers-in-law**. After the father's death, **brothers** typically separate into their own households, though they remain within the same **bari**.
- While **patrilineal ties** dominate, **matrilineal ties** also play a crucial role. **Married women** maintain connections between their **husbands' families** and their own **brothers**. **Women inherit property** by **Islamic law**, but often **forgo their claims** to keep land within the **patrilineal line**, ensuring their place in their **brothers' homes**.
- A woman's **respect** and **security** in her **in-laws' household** grow after bearing a **son**. **Mothers** tend to be emotionally closest to their **sons**, while **daughters** face **stricter discipline** and **heavy household chores**. **Fathers** are distant figures, and a **son's wife** may remain a **stranger** in the family for a long time after marriage.



Marriage in Bangladesh

Marriage in Bangladesh is primarily a **civil contract** rather than a **religious sacrament**, with **families** playing a key role in selecting spouses. While **men** in **urban middle-class families** may influence their choice, **women**—except in **elite circles**—have little say. **Marriages** typically occur between families of **similar status**, though **financial standing** has become a more significant factor, often favoring **men with jobs abroad**.

Extensive **negotiations** between families precede marriages to balance any **status differences** through **financial arrangements**. The **groom's family** pledges a **bride-price**, which can serve as **financial security** for the wife in case of **divorce**. Some families also follow the **Hindu practice of dowry**.

Etiquette

- **Personal interaction** is initiated with the greeting **Assalamu Walaikum** ("peace be with you"), to which the required response is **Walaikum Assalam** ("and with you"). Among **Hindus**, the correct greeting is **Nomoshkar**, as the **hands** are brought together under the chin.
- **Men** may shake hands if they are of **equal status**, but do not grasp hands firmly. **Respect** is expressed after a handshake by placing the **right hand** over the heart. **Men and women** do not shake hands with each other. In **same-sex conversation**, **touching** is common, and individuals may stand or sit **very close**. The closer individuals are in terms of **status**, the closer their spatial interaction is. **Leave-taking** is sealed with the phrase **Khoda Hafez**.
- **Differences in age** and **status** are marked through **language conventions**. Individuals with higher status are not addressed by personal name; instead, a **title** or **kinship term** is used.
- **Visitors** are always asked to sit, and if no chairs are available, a **low stool** or a **bamboo mat** is provided. It is considered improper for a visitor to sit on the **floor** or **ground**. It is incumbent on the **host** to offer guests something to eat.
- In crowded **public places** that provide services, such as **train stations**, the **post office**, or **bazaars**, **queuing** is not practiced, and receiving service is dependent on **pushing** and maintaining one's place within the throng. **Open staring** is not considered **impolite**.

ETHNIC GROUPS IN BANGLADESH



The Indigenous People

For centuries, Bangladesh has been the dwelling place of different ethnic groups. In fact, 35 smaller groups of indigenous people covering about two percent of the total population have been living in different pockets of the hilly zones and some areas of the plain lands of the country.

The Indigenous People of Bangladesh are living mostly in the Chittagong Hilly areas. The communities are defined as distinct groups of people, socially, economically, and politically. They are also known as Tribal People or Ethnic Group or Minorities in Bangladesh. The life and culture of the Indigenous people are extremely fascinating. They are mostly from Buddhists. Some of the communities are also from Christians, Hindus as well as Animists. The primitive lifestyles are also seen among most of the ethnic group. In general, women do more hard-working activities than males.



সম্প্রীতির বান্দরবান





The Chakma (Changma) Community

- The **Chakma (Changma)** is the **largest tribal community in Bangladesh**. They are of **mixed origin**, though they reflect **more Bengali influence than any other tribe**.
- They are predominantly settled in the **Chittagong Hill Tracts**—including **Rangamati, Bandarban, and Khagrachhari**—and also in **Cox's Bazar**. The Chakmas originate from **Mongoloid people** of **Southwestern Burma**.
- They speak in both their **dialect (Arakanese – an Indo-European tongue)** and **Bengali**. Among the tribal groups of Bangladesh, the Chakmas are especially **rich in culture and tradition**.

Cultural Identity

Culturally, the Chakmas are **more Southeast Asian than South Asian** in many aspects. They do **not follow the strict dietary restrictions** or **gender segregation** that are common among their Bengali neighbors.

[Willem Van Schendel]



The Chakma Community

Lifestyle and Culture

- Their **houses are traditionally built with bamboo**, though **modern architectural styles** are also being adopted in recent times.
- They depend mainly on **agriculture**, practicing an **eco-friendly method known as "Jhum cultivation"** to grow various crops.
- **Chakma women** typically wear **homemade Pinon and Khadi**, while **men wear Dhuti**.
- The Chakma community possesses its **own script**, and **ancient religious texts** are written in their dialect on **palm leaves**.

Religion and Celebrations

- The **vast majority of Chakmas are Buddhists**, forming the **largest Buddhist population in Bangladesh**. Their **Buddhist practices are blended with older animistic traditions**, including the **worship of natural forces**.
- One of the major cultural highlights is the **Bizu Festival**, celebrated in **Chaitra**, the **last month of the Bengali calendar**. It is a **three-day-long festival** and is observed as a **public holiday in the Chittagong Hill Tracts**.



Marma tribe

- Marma Tribe (Also known as Moghs or Maghs) is the second largest tribal group in Bangladesh.
- Marmas belong to the Mongoloid race.
- They live in the Chittagong Hills region (Especially in Bandarban, Khagrachari and Rangamati Hill Districts, Cox's Bazar and Patuakhali) in Bangladesh. Still, some of them are living in Tripura, India, and Myanmar.
- The origin of Marmas is from Burmese (Myanmar) ancestry. So, they lead the cultural life as like the Burmese and their dress and script are also from pure Burmese.
- They speak in Arakanese dialect and their language is written in Burmese characters. Marmas in urban areas and nearby settlements speak the corrupt local language of Chittagong.
- They follow the religion of animistic Buddhism.
- They are depending on plow agriculture.
- Marma men and women typically wear 'thami' (sarong) and 'angi' (blouse). However, the angi used by the men is more a waistcoat than a blouse. Marmas make their own dresses using traditional weaving technology, although many now purchase common Bangali dresses from the market.
- In general, the culture of Marma Tribe is unique. They have their own dress, food habits, songs, musical instruments as well as religious belief. They observe their own festivals. The biggest one is Sangrai. It is the festival of observing New Year according to the Buddhist lunar calendar. It is also known as the Water Festival. They splash one each other during the festivals. They believe the water will remove the sorrows and clear the mind and body.



Tripura tribe

- The Tripuras mainly live in Khagrachari District of Chittagong Hilly areas. Besides, the small group of the Tripuras also live in Comilla, Noakhali, Chandpur as well as Moulavibazar.
- The total number of people in this community is nearly 1 lac in Bangladesh. They are now proud citizens of this country. On the other hand, Tripura is also live in India.
- The Tripura Tribe or Community is divided into 36 clans or dofas or sub-groups.
- The language Tripura is known as Kokborok. More than 1 Million people talks in this language.
- Boishu is the main festival of the Tripura ethnic group. Most of the Tripuras now believe in Hinduism though they have their own God also. Now, some of them are converting into Christianity.



Santals tribe

- The Santals are another oldest and largest Indigenous community in Bangladesh. They are mostly living in the Rajshahi and Rangpur division. On the other hand, The Santals also live in India, Myanmar, and Nepal.
- They talk in their Santali (Austroasiatic/Munda) language. This tribe people are living from thousands of years ago.
- The Santals believe that their origins are from the seven pairs of children of the first human the Peelchu Buro and the Peelchu Buri. That is why the Santals are divided into seven groups. These tribes are called Parris in Santali language. Now the Santals are divided into seven subgroups.
- The Santals are very rich in culture. According to the groups they believe in different Gods. For example, Sari Dharam, Sarnaism, Hinduism, and Christianity. The Supreme Deity of Santal is Marang Buru or Bonga.
- They are very simple and love nature. Now the Santals people are encouraging their child to take education. They love entertainments and festivals. They observe Sohrai as their principal festivals. Alongside, they also observe Baha, Karam, Dansai and many other festivals. The dance of Santals is very popular among the tribal people.
- Socially, they believe in Patriarchy. The son gets all the property and if the father wishes, he can give his daughter some portion of it. Otherwise, the girl will not get anything. Mostly they like to eat rice and meat. They lead their life with agriculture. Similarly, the Santals are interested in art.

Garo

- Garo, an ethnic group in Bangladesh belonging to Bodo sub-sect of the Tibeti-Burman sect of Mongoloid race. They also live in Indian state of Meghalaya. The present population size of Garo in Bengladesh is 150,000. They live in the districts of Tangail, Jamalpur, Sherpur, Mymensingh, Netrakona, Sunamganj, Sylhet and Gazipur with a highest concentration in Haluaghat and Dhobaura upazilas of Mymensingh, Durgapur and Kalmakanda upazilas of Netrokona, Nalitabari and Jhenaigati upazilas of Sherpur and Madhupur upazila of Tangail district.
- The Garo people of Bangladesh, who often identify themselves and their language as "Mandi," actually speak several distinct mother-tongue languages or dialects.They would like to introduce themselves in their language as Mandi, the daughter of nature. They worship nature and its objects.
- They are also familiar with the name of A·chik Mande (That means Hilly People or the soul of hill).
- Most of the Garo People follow the religion of Christianity. Some of them are also from Animist and they are known as Songsarek, their tribal religion. They talk in their own Garo language which has come from Tibeto-Burman language family. They talk in their dialects also. Important to realize, there are more than 10 dialects according to the clans.
- The Garo society is matrilineal, and mothers inherit property and they are the head of their respective families. They also take the title of their mother. Each husband or the father of children works as a manager of the family. At present, the male children are also given shares in the landed property through registered deeds in Garo society during the lifetime of their parents.
- They observe different types of festivals depending on the Agricultural crops. The biggest popular one is Wangala.

Khasi

- Khasi People live in India and Bangladesh in the Khasi and Jaintia hill. The Khasi are an indigenous people, the majority of whom live in the State of Meghalaya in North East India, with small populations in neighbouring Assam, and in parts of Bangladesh. They call themselves Ki Hynñiew trep, which means "the seven huts" in the Khasi language.
- The Khasi people who reside in the hilly areas of Sylhet, Bangladesh, are of the War sub-tribe.
- Their language Khasi is the northernmost Austroasiatic language. A substantial minority of the Khasi people follow their tribal religion, called variously Ka Niam Khasi and Ka Niam Tre in the. Other religions practised include Presbyterian, Anglican, Unitarian, Roman Catholic, and very few are Muslims. The main crops produced by the Khasi people living in the War areas, including Bangladesh, are betel leaf, areca nut, and oranges. The War-Khasi people designed and built the living root bridges of the Cherrapunjee region. The Khasis are a matrilineal society.



Monipuri

Monipuri is one of the ethnic groups of Bangladesh. Their original abode is in the Monipur state of Asam in India. They live in Sylhet, Moulovibazar, Habiganj district.

The Monipuris are divided into two groups.

- 1. Bishnupriya Monipuri
- 2. Moi Toi Monipuri

- The name of the languages of these two groups is by the name of their groups.
- The culture of the Monipuris is much enriched. Dance is one of the parts of their culture. They are the followers of old religion. There is a Monipuri Muslim group named 'Moi Toi Pangn’.
- The staple food of Munipurs is rice, fish, dried fish and vegetables. However, since meat is socially prohibited, they do not eat it. They like eating a kind of salad called 'sincheda' made of leaves of vegetables.
- Agriculture is the occupation of most of the Monipuris. They cultivate different types of crops and vegetables. They have weaving industry at their homes. Nowadays they are entering in all the occupations.
- The houses of the Monipuris are made of bamboo. They also have brick built or tin shed houses.
- They keep their houses neat and clean. The merriments of Monipuris go on round the year through festivities. They rejoice through dance, music, musical instruments. They celebrate Rathajatra, Doljatra, Holi festival, Chaitra Sangkranti, Rashpurnima etc.



Other Tribal People In Bangladesh

There are many other tribal communities in Bangladesh. Among them are the Jaintia, Tanchangya, Khumi, Mro, Lushai, Khiang, Bawm, Pankhu, Chak, Rakhine, and Keot (Kaibarta) tribes. Additionally, the “Pangal” or “Pangan” represent Muslim tribal groups. Other notable communities include the Sadri and Chak tribes.

